what resembles the grave but isn't

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/30832568.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Growing Apart, Adora Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, and also probably, Catra Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Angst, Teen Angst, bildungsroman, but also a, Short, Short One Shot, Sad Ending, Ambiguous/Open Ending, Coming of Age, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Alternate Universe - Modern: No Powers, the deleted scene set between the graduation chapter and the orientation chapter of a, Alternate Universe - High School, and a, Alternate Universe - College/University, Fic, Hurt No Comfort, Adora-centric (She-Ra), POV Adora (She-Ra), Growing Up, Unrequited Crush, Requited Unrequited Crush

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2021-04-22 Words: 1,099 Chapters: 1/1

what resembles the grave but isn't

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/30832568.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Growing Apart, Adora Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, and also probably, Catra Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Angst, Teen Angst, bildungsroman, but also a, Short, Short One Shot, Sad Ending, Ambiguous/Open Ending, Coming of Age, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Alternate Universe - Modern: No Powers, the deleted scene set between the graduation chapter and the orientation chapter of a, Alternate Universe - High School, and a, Alternate Universe - College/University, Fic, Hurt No Comfort, Adora-centric (She-Ra), POV Adora (She-Ra), Growing Up, Unrequited Crush, Requited Unrequited Crush

Language:
English

Stats:

Published: 2021-04-22 Words: 1,099 Chapters: 1/1

what resembles the grave but isn't

by forwantofanoxfordcomma

Summary

Adora is eighteen years old. She shouldn't have to stand around waiting while Razz finishes chatting with the neighborhood "PTA moms" and drags her home.
But. But at least. At least she has fifteen minutes or so to pop inside Catra's house and check in on her. They haven't really talked in a while, but they were attached at the hip when they were kids. Entrapta says Catra's right inside. Adora will go in and say something clever and they'll hit it off again and then she won't feel so awkward texting. And then maybe they won't stop talking even when Adora goes to that out-of-state school she's been accepted into.
Hopefully, anyways.

Notes

so i usually project onto catra because anger management buddies but sometimes i am willing to be dumb socially awkward blonde jock lesbian buddies with adora instead. i'm magnanimous like that.
the title of this fic comes from a lovely little poem about getting back on your feet until you can't. that's a little bit how some longtime friendships can work if both parties aren't putting in the work. look it up after you finish this; it's much less depressing.

See the end of the work for more notes

Adora enters the house.

It looks like it has always looked, cozy in an empty far-away kind of way. There is a cat— Molag, Adora remembers vaguely— sprawled across Catra's favorite spot on the old sofa. Molag is old and tired, no longer the spry little thing from Adora's memories. She blinks lazily at Adora, not even shifting when she strokes the cat's spine carefully.

And there is Catra— beautiful and brilliant as ever. She is sitting at a dining room table covered in books. All of the other chairs have been dragged against the wall, but not Catra's. It is pressed against the head of the table, just a few inches too close.

Catra is skinny— thin as a rail. Skinnier than she used to be. Much skinnier than she should be. She sits in her too-close chair pressed against her too close table.

"Hey," Adora says, mostly because she can't think of anything else to say. It's not very clever. Adora tries not to wince and mostly succeeds.

"Oh, hi," says Catra, not looking up. She is holding a well-worn copy of Fahrenheit 451. The spine is cracked. Catra is fixing it, focused completely. She carefully orders each page, gluing them together and smoothing them out with her nails. She trims the excess with a pair of green scissors that may have once belonged to Adora.

If Adora is being honest with herself, she is hurt by the dismissal.

No lilting 'hey, Adora'. No long gazes held precious between them. No lingering consideration. Just 'oh, hi,'. Why hasn't she looked up?

Adora rounds the table.

Ten years ago— hell, two years ago— Adora might have felt comfortable pulling up a chair or examining the stacks or

something, but it's not two years ago. It's today.

Adora stands as still as she can, watching Catra fix books.

Catra doesn't look up.

Fahrenheit 451 goes in a stack to the left. Next up is Tom Sawyer.

"So, library sciences?" Adora asks.

"Not really," Catra says. She's glaring at a page that looks like it lost a fight to a paper shredder. "Just doing some maintenance on my bookshelf."

She's not looking up. Why won't she look up?

"Fair enough," Adora says. "Because you don't want to do the studying, or 'cause you already know everything and you'd be bored?"

For a moment, it is quiet again.

Adora checks her phone. Seven more minutes before Razz— well, before Adora turns into a pumpkin.

Figuratively.

Catra used to always tear the tape with her teeth. Now she cuts it into precise strips with her green scissors.

God, she's so pretty. Why is she not looking up?

Catra looks up. But not at Adora. She looks up at her books, examining each of the nearest piles of books with a careful eye. Tom Sawyer goes into the left pile. Zen and the Art of Motorcycle Maintenance takes its place. She looks down again.

"I don't know everything," Catra says. She won't look at Adora.

There is an ugly feeling in Adora's chest.

"But I do know enough to know it's better as a hobby for me," Catra says, not looking up. Adora takes a steadying breath. She smiles and hopes Catra can't tell that it's been plastered on.

"I would pull the stars from the sky if you asked," Adora wants to tell her. *"I would stack them up in mason jars and label them with masking tape and a metallic gold Sharpie."*

Catra trims the binding carefully. It tears. She sighs and pulls out a needle and thread from behind the stack on the right.

"I would boil them into tea for you to drink, press them into paper for you to write on."

Molag grumbles something. Catra's thimble protects her nimble fingers. She's done this before. She'll do this again.

"I would slice them into pieces so thin you could thread them through your needle. I would burn them to ashes to keep you warm. If you asked."

Catra can't read minds. She just— she just keeps stitching. She's careful. She's lovely.

Adora wants to cry.

Catra doesn't look up.

There is a chasm of years between them. It spans bitterness and friendship and misunderstandings and trust. It starts with the table where Catra sits— the table that Adora remembers piled with snacks for Catra's sleepovers and playdates— and travels over three chairs— covered in cat fur and glitter and brightly colored feathers from all the crafts they used to do here— and stops at the edge of the carpet where Adora hovers— the carpet they stained with superglue and blood and that one stolen margarita and layer after layer of glitter and flour and stupid fake feathers and uncooked macaroni noodles.

The carpet that Adora can't step onto right now.

Adora doesn't have to check her phone.

It's been seven minutes. Razz will be waiting. Razz is not patient.

"I've gotta go," Adora says.

Catra doesn't look up when she leaves.

Catra doesn't care.

Adora shouldn't either. People grow apart. That's life.

Especially for kids. Adora is barely eighteen. She hasn't really seen Catra since she turned sixteen. They haven't had a full conversation since freshmen year in high school. It's perfectly normal for Catra to not care.

Adora wonders desperately if Catra will look up when the door closes behind her.

She hopes that she will.

She doubts it.

So Adora leaves. Catra doesn't look up. Adora hopes. Adora doubts. The door swings shut behind her.

(The door closes with a loud noise like a frightened animal. The wood is old and the springs haven't been oiled since Catra slathered them in literal olive oil as a child because Adora said it worked in this spy movie she watched. Catra carefully arranges the book on the table in front of her, pushing the needle into her pincushion.

Catra is not in the mood for book repair anymore.

She doesn't look up.

Can't, or won't. Who knows the difference anyway.

Catra lets out a heavy sigh and pushes everything to the side.

She will go upstairs and brush her teeth and climb into bed and shimmy out of her skinny jeans and go to sleep and when she wakes up, then she can pretend to be unaffected by all this. But for now, she just stares at the perfectly-sized, perfectly-sharpened bright green scissors and lets herself mourn.

Because that is what this is, this dissonance and loss and distance.

This is Catra, torn up over whatever it is that Adora has left behind.

This is not unusual for Catra.)

End Notes

i tagged this as "ambiguous ending" b/c in real life the people you grow apart from very rarely think of you as their soulmate and want to marry you and kiss you and buy houses together, and in theory, they could reunite later in life and co-parent some cats together, but i also tagged "sad ending" because that can't happen until they both get their lives together and grow as people and ensure independent financial security and maybe even get a therapist.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!